Actionable feedback

Giving students a useful next step

Use individual feedback when a precise next action can improve work while the thinking is still live. Make the location, learning issue and required change clear.

How to do it well

1 Plan and break the plane early. Name the success criteria, must-check pupils and a predictable route before work begins.

2 Cover the full field. Move systematically, stay aware of the room and avoid reactive zig-zagging or repeatedly visiting the same pupils.

3 Diagnose before feeding back. Scan, read and compare with the criteria; note exemplars, partial attempts, misconceptions and pupils to revisit.

4 Use prompt, clue, then direct. Start with the least support likely to activate the pupil's knowledge; escalate only when the response shows it is needed.

5 Bound the action. Identify the exact location and a finite improvement that the pupil can complete now.

6 Return and respond. Check the change, praise against criteria and pause for whole-class correction when the same misconception is widespread.

What this sounds like

“Your claim is clear. In this sentence, add evidence that supports it. Tell me what you will change, then make the edit and I will return.”

Classroom example. In PE, a pupil receives feedback on one feature of a taught movement. The teacher identifies what is already successful, gives a precise next action and asks for another attempt. A later return checks the change. The feedback is short enough to use immediately and does not become a list of every possible improvement.

Top tips that make the technique work

Begin with the successful feature. Precise recognition tells the pupil what to retain while improving another part.

Use prompt, clue, direct. Start with a question if the pupil has the knowledge; provide more guidance when the response shows it is needed.

Bound the action. One sentence or process step is easier to act on than “improve your explanation”.

Ask for immediate work. A feedback conversation should end with the student thinking, writing, rehearsing or trying again.

Return later. Check the change and an additional attempt rather than assuming the comment was understood.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Name the exact feature and next action.	Vague praise followed by “more detail”.
Check listening and require a response.	Giving the answer when a usable prompt would suffice.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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